

Cape porcupine

Hystrix africaeaustralis

porcupine raises
quills to make
itself look bigger



This impressive rodent has taken defense to the extreme. All along its back are sharp spines called quills, which are modified hairs up to 12 in (30 cm) long. If threatened, the Cape porcupine flicks these out to form a black-and-white crest, while stomping its feet and shaking its

hollow tail quills like a rattle. This dramatic display is enough to deter most predators. Porcupines are born with soft quills and stay in the family burrow for around two months until their quills have hardened. Adults live in pairs and form a close bond.

- ↔ 25–32 in (63–81 cm)
- ⚖ 22–53 lb (10–24 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌱 Roots, bulbs, tubers, fruit
- 🏠   



C. to Southern
Africa



⚠ WATCH OUT!

If an inexperienced predator such as a leopard or lion cub attacks a porcupine, it risks a paw- or face-full of quills. If the wounds become infected, it may even die.

